

INDEPENDENT · READER-FUNDED · MADE IN CHATTANOOGA

The Scenic City Insider

Your weekly field guide to the people building Chattanooga.

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Morning, Scenic City.

This week we meet a man who builds drums one at a time, tell you the 107-year story of a single room on Rossville Avenue, and — up on the site — drop our first long-form *Flagship*. Pour the coffee.

WHAT'S NEW AROUND TOWN

↗ **Now open** — **The Reading Room** (3210B Brainerd Rd). Owner **Linden Marno-Feree** built a bar inside a bookstore — and sources the books through the Chattanooga Public Library Foundation, sending a cut of every sale back to it. A drink that funds library books: we're in.

↗ **Also new** — **Pedestrian Wine & Cheese** on Frazier Ave is — by their telling — the first Tennessee shop licensed to sell house-made cheese. Pick a bottle, add a wedge they cut and aged themselves.

Just Licensed (members first): a new Filipino food trailer and a Guatemalan bakery both filed this month. Members get names, locations, and first-taste reports as we confirm them.

MEET A MAKER

Pelfrey Drum Works

Hixson · Jerry “Punkin” Pelfrey

That snare cracking through a set at a Southside bar might have been born in a Hixson workshop. **Jerry “Punkin” Pelfrey** has been building drums since the '90s; today he makes stave snare drums one at a time — gluing, turning, and tuning each shell by hand — and ships them to players around the world.

It's the opposite of a factory: slow, single-batch, built to outlast the drummer. This is what we mean by “who made this?”

THE BUILDING'S BIOGRAPHY

1627 Rossville Avenue

Before the new sign goes up, the story of the room.

From **1918 to 2025**, this address fed Chattanooga as **Zarzour's** — four generations of a Lebanese-American family, plate-lunch lines out the door, and a counter where the whole city seemed to take a turn. When it closed last year after 107 years, it was the oldest restaurant in town.

This summer it becomes **Pauly's**. Same walls, new chapter — and the new owners say they're keeping the bones. We'll be there the morning the screen door swings open again. Every storefront has layers. We'll keep digging them up.

THIS MONTH'S FLAGSHIP · ON THE SITE

“Whiskey to the People”

Distilling was illegal in Hamilton County for 104 years. Our first long-form profile is the story of the people who changed the law — and rebuilt distilling on the very street it was born on.

[Read the full Flagship →](#) (Founding Insiders get it in print.)

THE STANDING INVITATION

Do this one thing this week

Beat the July heat: a weekday-morning climb up **Stringer's Ridge** before 9am. It's an in-town trail most visitors never find — twenty minutes of easy switchbacks to a skyline view of the whole city and the river bend. Bring water, leave the earbuds out, and let the city wake up below you.

YOU TOLD US

A reader insisted I try the crepes at **Sully's** on the North Shore; another swears **Clumpie's** is the only correct answer to a July evening. Both were right. What did I miss? Reply.

Still ad-free, still working for you. If issue No. 2 earned a few minutes of your morning, **forward it** to a friend — and keep the replies coming.

***Founding Insiders** get the print Getaway Field Guide and the annual Almanac mailed to their door. More on that soon.*

Yours in the Scenic City,

[Your Name]

Founder & Insider-in-Chief

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